

A GUIDE FOR PARENTS & CAREGIVERS

Understanding Your Child

A Parent's Guide to the Crucial Cs

Based on Adlerian play therapy

Play is a child's natural language. Through it, kids show us how they see themselves, other people, and the world. This guide draws on Adlerian play therapy (developed by Terry Kottman from Alfred Adler's ideas) to help you understand why your child acts the way they do, and how to help them feel they belong, can do hard things, and truly matter.

Why Kids Act the Way They Do

Every child wants to belong

Adler believed we are all born wanting to be part of a group and to contribute to it. A child who feels they belong and can help out is a child who is doing well.

Behavior has a purpose

Kids rarely act "for no reason." Instead of only asking "Why did you do that?", ask yourself "What is this behavior getting my child?"

Kids make their own "rules"

From family life, children form private beliefs about how to fit in (for example, "I only matter when I win"), Some of these beliefs are mistaken, and we can gently help change them.

Respect goes both ways

Children do best when adults share some power and choices with them, while still keeping firm, safe limits.

Anchored Inside Counseling Services · Jessica Prosser, LPC





The Four Crucial Cs

Lew & Bettner · Four beliefs every child needs. When one is missing, kids feel discouraged, and that often shows up as misbehavior.

Connect: "I belong"

When it's there: Your child makes friends, shares feelings, and feels secure in the family and in groups.

When it's missing: Your child may feel left out or lonely, push people away, or seek attention in negative ways.

Try this week:

- Spend regular one-on-one time doing something they choose.
- Name their feelings: "You seem really frustrated."
- Read a story together and talk about how the characters feel.

Capable: "I can take care of myself"

When it's there: Your child is self-reliant, manages themselves, and takes responsibility.

When it's missing: Your child may feel "I can't," try to boss others around, or lean on you for everything.

Try this week:

- Don't rescue: "I think you can figure that out. Want to try first?"
- Teach one real skill step by step (pour cereal, pack a bag).
- Hand responsibility back for small choices and tasks.

Count: "I matter, just as I am"

When it's there: Your child feels important without having to earn it, and knows they make a difference.

When it's missing: Your child may withdraw, act like a show-off, or feel they only matter when they perform.

Try this week:

- Give a real job the family depends on (feeding the pet, setting the table).
- Thank them for their contribution: "That helped all of us."
- Notice their strengths out loud, separate from grades or wins.

Courage: "I can handle what comes"

When it's there: Your child tries new things and takes healthy risks.

When it's missing: Your child may avoid challenges, quit quickly, or say "I'm bad at everything."

Try this week:

- Let them see you make mistakes: "Oops, I burned the toast. I'll try again."
- Break big tasks into small, doable steps.
- Offer a choice instead of fixing it for them.



Your Child's Coping Style

Kfir; Pew; Langenfeld & Main · Under stress, kids (and adults!) lean on one of four "personality priorities." Each has strengths and stumbling blocks.

The Controller

Wants order and hates feeling helpless.

Strengths: a leader, reliable.

Watch for: rigidity, power struggles, perfectionism.

The Pleaser

Wants approval and avoids conflict.

Strengths: kind, cooperative.

Watch for: worry, trouble saying no.

The Achiever

Wants to excel and fears being unimportant.

Strengths: high standards, hard worker.

Watch for: overworking, self-criticism, fear of failing.

The Comfort-Seeker

Wants ease and avoids stress.

Strengths: easygoing, caring.

Watch for: passivity, avoiding hard things.

Your goal isn't to change your child's style. Help them use its strengths.



Decoding Misbehavior

Dreikurs & Soltz · Your own feeling is a clue. Ask, "How do I feel right now?" and follow the row across.

How do I feel?	Child's goal	What my child believes	Missing C	What to try instead
Annoyed	Attention	"I only belong when I'm the center of attention."	Connect	Don't reward the demand. Give lots of attention at calm times, and gently name the pattern: "I notice you want me to watch you."
Angry, challenged	Power	"I only belong when I'm the boss."	Capable	Step out of the tug-of-war. Offer limited choices and use calm, logical consequences.
Hurt	Revenge	"I'm hurt, so I'll hurt back."	Count	Stay calm and don't retaliate. Keep firm limits and show you still care.
Hopeless	Giving up	"I can't do it, so why try?"	Courage	Encourage steadily and skip criticism. Start with easy wins and celebrate small efforts.

Breaking the "Box"

Labels like "wild," "smart," "lazy," "good," or "bad" can become a box. Adults start overlooking anything that doesn't fit, and the child keeps acting out the label.

Stay neutral

Respond with calm, logical consequences, not big emotional reactions that confirm the label.

Catch the exceptions

Notice when your child acts outside the box, and say so: "You were so patient with your sister."

Reframe it

Reframe it: "Argumentative" can become "a leader with passion." "Messy" can become "creative."

Separate the deed from the doer

"That choice hurt someone," not "You're mean." Talk about actions and effort, not who they are.



Encouragement vs. Praise

Praise isn't bad, but encouragement builds a child's own confidence.

Praise

- Focuses on the person: "You're such a good boy."
- Comes mostly with success
- Teaches kids to look for approval: "Did I do good?"
- Can feel conditional
- Can raise anxiety

Encouragement

- Focuses on effort: "You worked hard on that puzzle."
- Notices progress, not perfection
- Builds inner satisfaction
- Feels unconditional
- Builds courage

Ready-to-Use Phrases

- "You can figure that out."
- "You kept trying even when it got hard."
- "You look proud of yourself."
- "It looks like you enjoyed painting that."
- "Thanks for helping. That made a difference."
- "I trust you to handle this."

Six Ways to Encourage

1. **Show faith**
   Trust them to handle things without rescuing.
2. **Notice effort**
   Name effort and progress, even when it isn't perfect, and skip the "but."
3. **Point inward**
   Ask how they feel about their work.
4. **Name strengths**
   Point out real skills and hidden talents.
5. **Be imperfect**
   Own your mistakes calmly; mistakes are how we learn.
6. **Get curious**
   Learn about their interests and really listen.

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The Cs in Modern Family Life

The same principles, applied to everyday challenges parents face today.

Screen time & power struggles

- When a battle over devices starts, it's often about power (Capable). Step out of the tug-of-war and share some control.
- Limited choices: "Do you want to turn it off now, or after this episode?"
- Logical consequences: calmly follow through on a limit you agreed on together, without lectures or anger.
- Agree on screen rules together so your child has a voice.

Busy schedules

- Rushed days can leave kids looking for attention in negative ways (Connect).
- Protect a short daily one-on-one time, even a few minutes, where your child chooses the activity.
- Give attention when it isn't demanded: a hug, a note, a "tell me about your day."
- Make chores shared family jobs, so kids help and feel needed.

Comparison & social media

- Highlight reels, for kids and parents alike, can send the message that you only matter when you perform (Count).
- Show your child they count without earning it: "I love spending time with you," with no achievement attached.
- Don't compare siblings or other kids. Focus on your child's own effort and progress.
- Model the courage to be imperfect. Share your own "not-highlight" moments.

When it gets hard

- Pause and ask: "How do I feel? Which C might be missing right now?" Then respond to the need, not just the behavior.

Sources: Kottman; Lew & Bettner; Kfir; Pew; Langenfeld & Main; Dreikurs & Soltz.